

HISTORY OF MILFORD

A mile and a half southwest from the mouth of the harbor, an island of about fourteen acres, partly wooded and partly open meadow, rose from the sea; a rocky bar awash at half-tide connected it with the mainland. The beaches abounded with clams; the harbor and the East River, with blue crabs; and the waters of the Sound, with lobsters and fish of many kinds.

Game was plentiful in the surrounding forests. There was an abundance of both hard and soft woods—oak, chestnut, butternut, hickory, maple, red cedar, hemlock, and elm. Wild beach plums, growing in profusion along the shore, offered fruit for preserves and jelly.

Who were the first settlers in Milford? Where did they come from? During the reign of Charles I, increasing numbers of people were migrating to New England because they were no longer willing to accept the tenets of the established Church of England, and had been persecuted by the prelates of the English Church for their non-conformity. In May, 1637, the *Hector* sailed from London to Boston, carrying a company gathered by John Davenport and Theophilus Eaton of London. Five weeks later another ship arrived with a group headed by Peter Prudden, a native of Hertfordshire. Among the original Milford settlers known to be of this company were Edmund Tapp, James Prudden, William Fowler, Thomas and Hannah Buckingham, Thomas Welch, Richard Platt, Henry Stonehill, and William East, all from Hertfordshire. The new arrivals stayed in the Massachusetts Bay Colony for almost a year, and were considered such desirable colonists that efforts were made to induce them to settle there permanently.

Davenport and Prudden, however, desired to establish their own colony, and when the potentialities of the region at the mouth of the Quinnipiac River in Connecticut were verified by an expedition made in August, 1637, by Eaton

A LITTLE REPUBLIC

settlement, but also the controlling force in colonial government, education, and social life. The leaders in the church were the leaders in civil affairs. Except for allegiance to the English Crown, which did not weigh too heavily upon the Fathers, they acknowledged no authority but the word of God, and "combined into a little republic." Their constitution was the Scriptures.

Prolonged discussions had occurred as to whether or not voting and office-holding should be confined to church members. The policy of excluding non-members from civil rights was finally adopted. The first General Court (town meeting), held on November 20, 1639, granted forty-four church members the franchise as "free planters." Following is the list taken from the town records:

Zachariah Whitman	Henry Stonhill	Thomas Lawrance
Thomas Welsh	Nathaniel Baldwin	Thomas Samford
Thomas Wheeler	James Prudden	Timothy Baldwin
Edmond Tappe	Thomas Baker	George Clarke, Jr.
Thomas Buckingham	George Clarke, Senr.	John Burwell
Richard Miles	George Hubburt	Henry Botsford
Richard Platt	Jasper Gunn	Joseph Baldwin
Thomas Topping	John Fletcher	Philip Hatly
Mr. Peter Prudden	Alex. Bryan	Nicholas Camp
William Fowler	Frances Bolt	John Rogers
John Astwood	Micah Tomkins	Thomas Uffott
Richard Baldwin	John Birdsey	Nathaniell Briscoe
Benjamin Fen	Edmond Harvy	Thomas Tibballs
Samuel Coley	John Lane	John Sharman
John Peacocke	William East	

The following persons are recorded immediately after, but not as free planters.

Robert Plum	John Baldwin	William Brookes
Roger Terrel	William Slough	Robert Treat
Joseph Northrupp	Andrew Benton	Henry Lyon

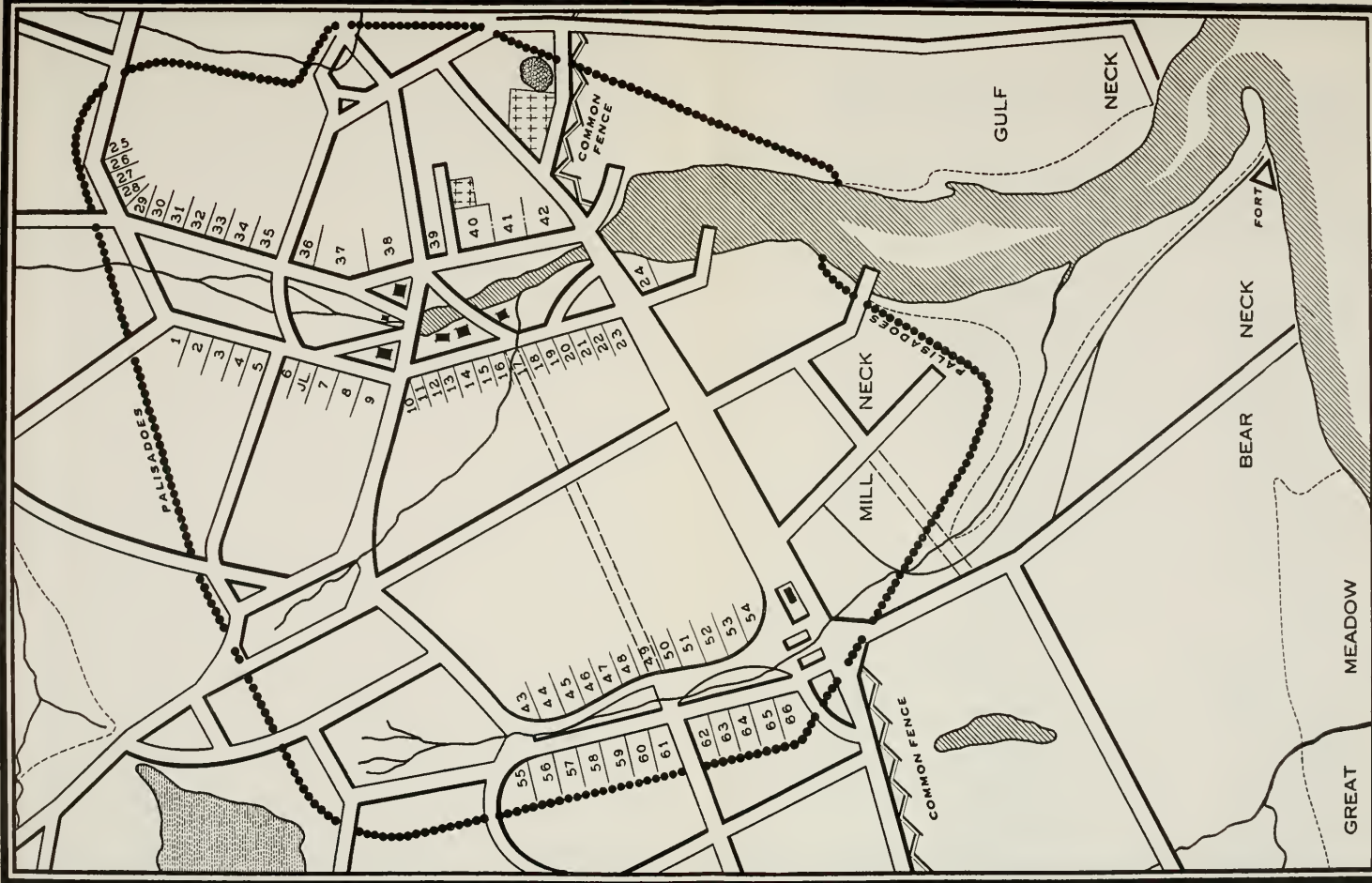
Lambert adds the name of John Fowler to this second list, but the name does not appear in the town records.

PLAN OF THE ORIGINAL TOWN PLOT OF MILFORD (After Lambert)

a, part of fresh meadow; b, part of dreadful swamp; c. part of Eastfield common line fence; d, part of Westfield common line fence. First Congregational meeting-house against lot No. 9; second Congregational meeting-house against No. 38; Episcopal Church against No. 17; and Town House against No. 15.

The location of the house of each first planter, as they were recorded in 1646, is seen on the plan of the town, by finding the same number which is prefixed to the name of each individual in the following list. The exact quantity of land in the house lot of each person, is here placed against his name:

	a.	r.	p.		a.	r.	p.
1 John Astwood	7	2	0	34 Thomas Wheeler	3	0	0
2 Richard Baldwin	3	0	0	35 Mr. Edmond Tapp	7	2	0
3 Benjamin Fenn	2	11	3	36 Tho. Buckingham	2	3	0
4 Samuel Cooley	2	1	20	37 Robert Plum	5	3	0
5 John Peacocke	1	3	0	38 Richard Platt	4	1	0
6 Henry Stonhill	2	3	20	39 Thomas Tapping	1	1	20
7 Nathaniel Baldwin	3	2	0	40 Mr. Peter Prudden	7	2	0
8 James Prudden	2	0	0	41 Mr. Wm. Fowler	7	2	0
9 John Sherman	4	0	0	42 Thomas Lawrence	1	0	0
10 Thomas Baker	3	2	0	43 George Clark, Junr.	4	1	0
11 Stephen Freeman	2	0	0	44 John Burwell	2	0	20
12 John Fletcher	2	3	30	45 Henry Botsford	2	2	0
13 John Baldwin	2	1	10	46 John Smith	1	3	20
14 Frances Bolt	2	1	20	47 John Rogers	1	3	20
15 Micah Tompkins	2	1	20	48 Philip Hatley	3	3	20
16 John Birdseye	2	3	20	49 Roger Tyrrell	2	3	20
17 Edward Harvey	2	3	0	50 Nicholas Camp	6	1	20
18 John Lane	2	2	20	51 John Fowler	1	2	20
19 William East	2	3	0	52 Joseph Baldwin	2	1	20
20 Thomas Lawrence	2	0	0	53 Thomas Tibbals	1	2	20
(sold to Wm. East.)				54 Wid. Martha Beard	4	1	00
21 Thomas Sandford	2	3	0	55 Thomas Campfield	3	0	0
22 Timothy Baldwin	4	0	0	56 Thomas Ford	3	0	0
23 Alexander Bryan	4	0	25	57 William Roberts	3	0	0
24 Jasper Gunn	0	3	0	58 John Smith	4	0	0
25 Tomas Hine	3	0	0	59 Thomas Bailey	3	0	0
26 Henry Lyon	3	0	0	60 William Brookes	3	0	0
27 John Stream	3	0	0	61 John Brown	3	0	0
28 William Slough	3	0	0	62 Nathaniel Briscoe	3	0	0
29 James Prime	3	0	0	63 Edward Riggs	3	0	0
30 Thomas Reed	3	0	0	64 Andrew Benton	3	0	0
31 Robert Denison	3	0	0	65 George Clark, Senr.	4	2	0
32 Zachariah Whitman	7	2	0	66 George Hubbard	4	2	0
33 Thomas Welch	4	2	0	(sold to John Stream.)			



PLAN OF THE ORIGINAL TOWN PLOT OF MILFORD IN 1646



SANFORD HOUSE



RICHARD PLATT HOUSE

HISTORY OF MILFORD

Another interesting house, but this time with a gambrel roof, is the stately home of Garrett Van Horn DeWitt, the merchant who came up to Milford from New York after the Revolution. The house, on the south side of Broad Street Green, lent an urban touch to the Connecticut village. The elaborate doorway and sidelights belong to the sophisticated period of the Greek Revival that was beginning to make itself felt in the centers. The Stephen Atwater Treat House (1798) on Gulf Street, is a more orthodox specimen of this period. The heavy piazzas are more modern than the rest of the house.

A perfect example of the Classical Revival house at the height of its effect on New England is the second Stephen Gunn House (1821), now an antique shop at the junction of US 1 and US 1A. The open pediment portico and simple, consistent detail give it an atmosphere of the early Federal period that is still authentic and unspoiled. A house of later date, in the fullness of the Greek Revival, is the Richard Platt House, the second house to the east of the Stephen Gunn House. Here the gable end faces the road, with a hip-roofed porch of perfect proportions over the door in the left corner. The fluted Ionic columns, the delicate detail of cornice and pediment remain. It is pleasing to find no details wiped out by asbestos shingling or other modern incongruity. Further to the east, a still later house, similar in plan but plainer in detail, reflects the growing simplicity of the later period of the Classic Revival. These three houses very aptly summarize its development.

Beyond question, the architectural distinction of Milford lies in its three old churches. It has an unusual number of houses of the Victorian period, from the Dennis Beach to the Harvey Beach Houses, which have fumbled through all sorts of experiments in form, some happy and some more or less bizarre. But in the two Congregational Churches (1823